

A LIMITED SERIES · TEN HOURS · FIVE STAGES

PLACES I CAN'T GO

She was taught to be invisible. It becomes the thing that saves her.

SERIES BIBLE & LOOKBOOK
DONOVAN JONES & JAMIE VANDYKE

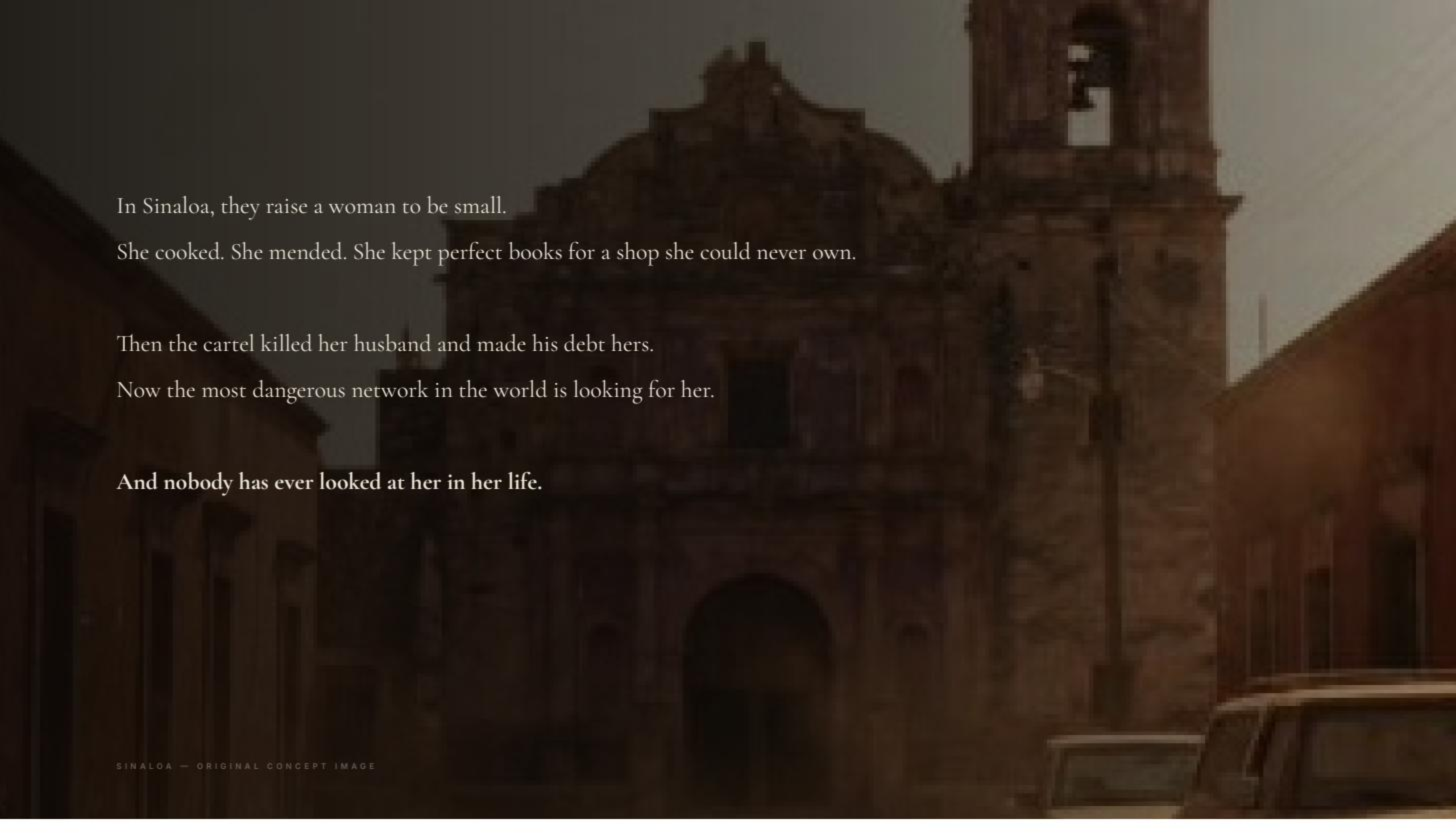
DRAFT — NOT SENT · 4:41 PM

Esme. Te amo. Perdóname por todo. Por favor|

He never finished the sentence.

She will.

It takes her ten hours, six countries, and everything she has.



In Sinaloa, they raise a woman to be small.

She cooked. She mended. She kept perfect books for a shop she could never own.

Then the cartel killed her husband and made his debt hers.

Now the most dangerous network in the world is looking for her.

And nobody has ever looked at her in her life.

This is a show about a **WIDOW** who buries a saint and grieves a liar.

This is a show about a **BOOKKEEPER** whose girlhood chores turn out to be the only skills that work.

This is a show about a **DEBTOR** who owes \$150,000 to people who kill for less.

This is a show about a **WITNESS** who saw exactly the wrong thing.

This is a show about a **GHOST** who orders coffee in Portuguese and never looks over her shoulder.

This is a show about Esmeralda.

You will meet her the way
everyone meets her:

by looking right past her.



THE DEVOTION — ORIGINAL CONCEPT IMAGE

\$25,000 in a bag. The last gift from a love lost.

It's not a fortune. It's the last piece of home she has left.

She'll do whatever it takes to get it back.

Upfront, you should know: this is a chase.
But the fuel is grief, and grief doesn't burn clean.

Part thriller. Part character study. Part dark comedy of one woman colliding with a continent
that can't see her and can't stop underestimating her.

Uncut Gems propulsion. *Volver* warmth. *Roma* intimacy. *City of God* life inside the informal world.

LOGLINE

When a cartel attack leaves her widowed and indebted, a sheltered bookkeeper from Sinaloa escapes to Naples with her husband's hidden savings — but after a street hustler steals it, she must chase the money through Europe's underground economies before the cartel finds her, discovering in the places she was told to fear the self she was taught to bury.

LIMITED SERIES · 10 × 60' DRAMA/THRILLER · GRIEF, MAPPED
SPANISH · ITALIAN · FRENCH · GERMAN · KRIOLU · PORTUGUESE

WHERE THIS GOES

By the end of the pilot, she's on a plane with \$25,000 in the lining and a price on her silence.

By episode three, she's auditing the Neapolitan underworld.

By episode seven, she spots the hunter's tell and walks out of a sealed city.

By episode nine, the money is gone, the flashbacks stop, and the show goes quiet.

By episode ten, she is a woman who does not exist.

And the hunter they sent signs the report that makes it official.



THE ENGINE

Every episode runs on three tracks.

01 — FIND THE MONEY

She arrives with a lead: what her savings became, who holds it, where it moved. To reach it she enters the underground city.

02 — SURVIVE THE CITY

The underground pulls her into a problem she didn't come to solve. Solving it — with the skills Sinaloa taught her — **is** the price of the next move.

03 — MAKE NO NOISE

The cartel's word moves the same networks. Every question she asks is a signal. Volume is the enemy. Warmth is the only safe currency.

EPISODE ARCHITECTURE

Cold open: she is already in the new city, already moving. We catch up to her. **Act one:** the underground, the contact, the pull. **Act two:** the situation deepens; the network stirs. **Act three:** ingenuity and relationships crack it open; the solution yields the trail. **Tag:** alone, she opens the text. Reads to where it stops. Then she moves.

Why these places? The underground was all she could afford. And the last place anyone expected a woman like her to go. The dangerous map is the only map that hides her.

THE WOMAN

ESMERALDA

Thirty-two. Devout. Underestimated. About to be none of those things.

She keeps the books for her husband's shop because he won't let her keep anything else. She cooks. She mends. She bargains in markets. She reads a room the way other people read a page.

She has never once called any of it a skill. She is about to learn that all of it is.

THE ARSENAL

A needle. A ledger. A pot of mole. Thirty-two years of small jobs, arriving all at once, with interest.

THE GIFT AND THE FLAW

They are the same instrument. She reads people fast, through the story she **expects** to find. In Sinaloa, it costs her a friendship: weeks spent convicting a good man while the truth assembles in plain sight. In Naples, it costs her everything: her trust handed to a charming stranger. Wrong both ways, for the same reason. The season is her learning the difference between certainty and sight.

THE ADVANTAGE

Every fence, broker, and enforcer in Europe underestimates her. A small, polite, praying widow who speaks only Spanish. It's why Nico misses the \$8,000 against her body. It's why she can stand next to the men looking for her. Being invisible was her cage for thirty-two years. **It becomes her weapon.**

The arc: from a woman who is certain to a woman who sees. The person who arrives in Lisbon is the original one, finally clear, finally claimed.



All her life she's been invisible.

The woman hunting her knows what that looks like.



Before we go any further, you should meet someone.

THE HUNTER

FERNANDA

The network doesn't use her name. They say: la que encuentra. The one who finds.

She finds people. Debtors who run. Partners who defect. Witnesses who saw. She has never hurt anyone in her life. She makes a phone call, and what happens after is someone else's job. Her record is perfect. Esmeralda is the first person in nineteen years she has failed to find in the first month. **It does something to her that she does not have a word for.**

THE OTHER BARGAIN

She came up in the same world. Poor, female, handed an identity and a fence around it. She watched that world erase her mother. And she made the opposite choice: she didn't flee the machine. She became its eyes. **The road not taken, with a phone and a perfect memory.**

WHY SHE'S LETHAL

Esmeralda's invisibility doesn't work on her, because she ~~was~~ her once, in the moment before choosing differently. The most understanding person in the show is the one dragging her home. **That understanding is the menace.**

*The mission: not a grave in Europe. A return ticket. The cartel wants the witness silenced and the example made **at home**. The threat isn't death.*

It's the title of the show.

TWO EXITS

Two girls from the same world.
Handed the same identity, and the same fence around it.

One fled the machine. / One became its eyes.

One prays. / One makes a phone call.

One is invisible because the world never looked. / One is invisible because she stands behind the glass.

One builds a network out of warmth. / One runs a network built on fear.

Same cage. Two exits.

The season is the argument between them.

TIAGO — *the husband*

A good man is not the same thing as a brave one. He inherited two things from his father: the shop's cartel debt, and the habit of hiding money against the day it came due. When the cartel calls it in, he works it off in the dark and lies to her face in the light.

The bag he leaves behind is his confession, his apology, and his love in a single object: **\$25,000, folded small, built over two generations.** Life insurance, for a man who could never afford the real kind.

He dies a martyr in public — shot shielding a child — and a liar in private — thrown out of his own house the night before. His town gets to grieve a saint. His wife has to grieve a man. She never gets to do it cleanly. That is the wound the season walks.



THE ABSENCE — ORIGINAL CONCEPT IMAGE

DRAFT — NOT SENT - 4:41 PM

Esme. Te amo. Perdóname por todo. Por favor!

He never finishes it. She opens it in every episode and reads to where it stops. In Lisbon, she writes the ending herself.

NICO — *the thief*

Neapolitan, twenty-six. He reads her in four seconds: alone, devout, lost, cash somewhere close. Two days of perfect kindness. Then he's gone, and so is the bag.

He misses the \$8,000 against her body **because it never occurs to him that a woman like her would know to put it there.** He is already wrong about her. He doesn't know it yet.

Behind him is a debt of his own and someone like Fernanda attached to it. When she finally corners him at the edge of the continent, there is nothing left to take. What she takes instead is more dangerous: **a use for him.**



THE NETWORK — ORIGINAL CONCEPT IMAGE

The constellation: **Don Chuy. Mamma Imma. Madame Bao and Awa. Gül. Zé and Dona Alice.** The people who don't sell her. Every one of them choosing not to.

Now, the money.

Everyone in the show is chasing it. You should at least get to hold it.

CARRIED OUT OF MEXICO	\$25,000
STOLEN IN NAPLES, DAY TWO	\$17,000
SEWN AGAINST HER BODY	\$8,000
OWED TO THE CARTEL	\$150,000

The season keeps its books on paper you could hold. Receipts. Market chits. Handwritten sums. Every episode closes with the count, and the count is the suspense: what she's recovered, what she's spent, what she owes. The audience keeps the books with her.

The math never closes.

It was never going to.

*"Grief turns out to be a place
none of us know until we reach it."*

— JOAN DIDION, THE YEAR OF MAGICAL THINKING

THE SHAPE OF THE SEASON

So we drew the map.

The five stages of grief, plotted across two continents. The story's organic shape. The stages bleed into each other, the way grief does.

Sinaloa

EP 1 • DENIAL

The world that was. The marriage, the debt, the siege, the bag, the plane.

Frankfurt

EPS 6-7 • BARGAINING

Broke in Europe's money capital. The first escape she architects.

Naples

EPS 2-3 • DENIAL → ANGER

The theft. The wrong cab. The first uncontrolled burst of self.

Rotterdam

EPS 8-9 • DEPRESSION

The trail ends at the water. His voice goes quiet. Then, the turn.

Paris

EPS 4-5 • ANGER

Cold, beautiful, indifferent. The first survival decision that is a choice.

Lisbon

EP 10 • ACCEPTANCE

The new name. The false trail. The text, completed. The life she chooses.

THE FLASHBACK SYSTEM

Tiago returns in memory, and the memories track the stages: tender in denial, harder in anger, wishful in bargaining. In depression they stop. The silence where his voice used to be is the season's lowest point. In acceptance, one final memory arrives that holds everything at once.

THE PALETTE IS THE JOURNEY

Sinaloa's ochre burns into Naples' saturation, cools through Paris' grey-blue and Frankfurt's steel, drops to Rotterdam's near-black. Then Lisbon opens into Atlantic light. You can read her interior state off any frame.

el duelo



EPISODE 1 · SINALOA, MEXICO · DENIAL — *Negación*

"The World That Was"

Told linear: a love story that becomes a loss in real time. We let the audience ahead of her once. It changes how the hour hurts.

THE HOURS

- Open on **her hands and the ledger**. The shop's numbers have stopped adding up. Her evidence points at **Don Chuy**, the old mechanic. It's genuinely damning. She is genuinely wrong.
- **We get ahead of her**: the cartel calls in the father's debt. \$200,000. Two weeks. Tiago runs product in the cars he fixes and lies about the late nights. We know the leak. We watch her build the wrong case.
- She goes to the shop at night to catch a thief and instead watches cartel men strip a truck for product. **She assembles it herself**. No confession needed. She throws him out. *Don't come home*. Their last conversation.
- The rival crew hits town. His calls ring out while she's herded into the church basement. Mid-text to her, he sees a child exposed in the crossfire. He pockets the phone. He goes for the boy. The line goes dead while she prays.
- The town buries a martyr. She grieves a liar she loved and threw out. She is alone inside the crowd, and stays that way for six countries.
- **Don Chuy brings the bag**. \$25,000, left with instructions. The man she convicted was the one protecting her all along. Her first correction.
- The cartel comes to collect. **\$150,000, one week**, an "arrangement" implied. In Culiacán, a thin file lands on a woman's desk. She reads it twice. She makes one phone call. **The word goes out**.
- The postcard of Italy. Dream money becomes escape money. The plane. She opens his draft and reads to where it stops.

WHAT THE HOUR PLANTS

Her deduction and her flaw in one move: right that something is wrong, wrong about what. The witnessing that makes her more than a debtor: **a loose end who saw the operation**. And the bag: love, apology, and confession in one object.

CARRIED OUT OF MEXICO	\$25,000
AGAINST HER BODY	\$8,000
OWED	\$150,000



EPISODES 2-3 · NAPLES, ITALY · DENIAL INTO ANGER — *La ira despierta*

"The Easy Mark" / "The Wrong Cab"

THE HOURS

- Their dream city, alone. She can't read a sign in any language around her. **Nico finds her in hours.** The good samaritan, the hostel, two days of earned trust. Then he's gone in the small hours, and so is the bag. She wakes to \$8,000 and a continent.
- **The wrong cab.** Certain she's spotted him, she erupts at a baffled Italian cab driver. A torrent of Spanish, thirty-two years of compliance detonating at the wrong man. It's comedy. It's the first uncontrolled burst of what's underneath. Wrong person, wrong language. *But she moved.* First green shoot.
- Broke, she's taken in by **Mamma Imma**, matriarch of an unlicensed kitchen in the Quartieri Spagnoli, who hires her hands before her story. Masa becomes dough. Her mole on a Neapolitan table buys her what money can't: standing.
- Imma's son **Ciro** is into a fence called **Salvo** — the same fence who moved Nico's stolen cash into contraband headed north. The house's problem and her problem are one problem. She spots what everyone missed: Salvo's ledger is padded. The bookkeeper's eye, weaponized for the first time.
- She trades the audit for **Ciro's debt** and a cut of recovered goods. **\$3,400 back, and the shape of the trail:** her money is goods now, moving north, shedding value at every conversion. To chase it is to enter the network that's hunting her.

THE HUNT

Fernanda works it from Cullacán first. Phones, favors, the Naples nodes. She lands eighteen hours behind, collects three descriptions, boards a train north. **We see her effects before we ever see her face.**

RECOVERED TO DATE	\$3,400
SPENT TO DATE	\$2,100
OWED	\$150,000

"City of Light, No Patience" / "Collateral"

THE HOURS

- Paris is cold, indifferent, and beautiful in a way that feels like a personal insult when you have nothing and speak only Spanish. The trail runs to counterfeit stock moving through **Madame Bao's** atelier in Aubervilliers and the Sentier's informal garment trade.
- Her needle buys her a bench. The girlhood skill nobody called a skill. Beside her, **Awa**, a Malian vendor who teaches her the market's real map: who's protected, who pays, who watches.
- The hardest flashbacks land here. Not his love. **His limitations**. She can love him and be furious at him for the same reasons: who he was is also what held her in place.
- A squeeze-man is taxing the stalls, and the description circulating for a "quiet Mexican widow" has reached his ears. He plans to sell her twice: once to his bosses, once to the network. Her play is the season's first cruelty: she feeds his skim to the people he answers to and lets them do the rest. **It works. It's a choice**. The cost sits on her.
- The stock moves through Awa's stalls; her cut comes to **\$2,700**, and an address where the value went next. Frankfurt.

THE HUNT

The network embarrassed her in Naples, so **Fernanda comes herself**. She walks the same market a day behind, buys the same coffee, asks better questions. By the end of episode five she has Esmeralda's face. Esmeralda's first escape that is a *choice* — planned, priced, paid for — happens one hour ahead of her.

RECOVERED TO DATE	\$6,100
SPENT TO DATE	\$4,600
OWED	\$150,000



EPISODES 6-7 · FRANKFURT, GERMANY · BARGAINING — *Negociación*

"The Money Capital" / "The Going Rate"

THE HOURS

- The sharpest irony in the show: she arrives broke in the financial capital of Europe. Her stolen value sits inside an informal transfer network thriving in the Bahnhofsviertel, in the shadow of the ECB. Two cities in one frame. She only ever belongs to the one below.
- Her money is behind a broker named **Milan**, who moves value for people who don't use banks. Nobody reaches Milan without a price. **Gül**, den mother of the block, teaches her the going rates for everything, including trust.
- The bargaining stage. The deals she makes with herself keep shifting: *if I recover this much, I'll stop. If I get far enough ahead, I'll go home.* The math never closes. She keeps recalculating.
- Milan's price is the bookkeeper's skill: his ledgers are being skimmed and he can't see where. **She audits the underground.** The woman who once built a wrong case on right numbers now follows the evidence instead of the story. Growth you can watch.
- Fernanda triggers the block's nodes. For the first time **Esmeralda spots the tell**: a repeated face, one question asked one wrong way. She architects the escape — a decoy through the station's rush, Gül's cousins, a route nobody sold. Imperfect. Hers. She walks out with **\$3,900** and the transfer's origin: Rotterdam. The port. A sender's name that sounds like Nico's.

THE HUNT

Fernanda is faster now. For the first time it still isn't enough. **She recalibrates: stop chasing where she's been. Start modeling where she'll go.** The endgame begins on the hunter's side of the board.

RECOVERED TO DATE	\$10,000
SPENT TO DATE	\$7,900
OWED	\$150,000

"The Arithmetic" / "Quiet"

The darkest frame before Lisbon's light. The visual grammar goes still, the way the flashbacks do.

THE HOURS

- The trail ends at the water. The last of the value went into a container that has already sailed. **It's gone.** She does the arithmetic in a boarding-house room on Katendrecht, and for the first time all season, the spent line crosses the recovered line.
- **Zé and Dona Alice** run the Cape Verdean bar below. Around their tables, for the first time in six countries, the language is almost hers. Kriolu, Portuguese: close enough to understand every third sentence. *Almost* turns out to be worse than nothing. So near the sound of home, and home is the one place she can't go.
- She reaches for Tiago's voice — the compass that has carried her through every city — **and it isn't there.** The flashbacks stop. The show's stillest hours.
- **Nico, cornered at last.** At the port, trying to buy passage with the last of what he took. There is nothing left to recover. What she gets instead is the truth: his debt, his own hunter, the same weather. She looks at the man she trusted and finally *sees* him. Frightened, small, useful. **She repurposes him.**
- **Fernanda's closest pass of the season.** A room away, one flight of stairs, the audience genuinely unsure for a full episode. What saves her is a phone call: Gül, through Imma's cousin. The warm network outrunning the cold one by minutes. Three countries of fed, mended, defended people becoming load-bearing at the exact moment nothing else holds.
- **The turn.** She stops running from Fernanda's method and starts reading it. If the network is how she's hunted, the network is a weapon anyone can hold. Nico starts seeding sightings of her moving east. She boards a bus going the other way. She doesn't need the voice. She has her own.



THE CANDLE — ORIGINAL CONCEPT IMAGE

THE HUNT

She has never been this close. And something evades her anyway. Something her tools can't name. **It's gratitude. Other people's.**

RECOVERED TO DATE	\$10,000
SPENT TO DATE	\$10,850
OWED	\$150,000

The line crosses. The math never closes. It was never going to.

"The New Name"

THE HOURS

- She arrives on the last of everything, carried in by the Cape Verdean web: Zé's people, Dona Alice's cousin, the paper man they trust. **Senhor Baptista**, who sells beginnings. The new identity costs **\$9,000**. Nearly all that remains. She pays it the way you pay for a life.
- **The false trail lands.** Nico's seeded sightings move through the fences, brokers, and kitchens. The cartel's own wires carry her lie for her. Fernanda's network eats its own information. The system that hunted her across a continent points east, at a woman who no longer exists.
- **Fernanda, in a Rotterdam room** Esmeralda slept in, understands fully and precisely, the way only she could: she has been beaten by the one currency she gave up. She files the report that sends the cartel east. Whether she believes a word of it is the question the show leaves on the table.
- The café above the Atlantic. The text, read one last time. And then, in the notebook, **she writes the ending herself.** The word he was reaching for. The word she has spent ten episodes earning.
- A passport with a name we've never heard. She says it aloud, once, alone. **It fits.** She orders in Portuguese. The light is the widest the show has ever allowed. She does not look over her shoulder.

WHY SHE WINS

She becomes Fernanda's equal as a reader of people, and keeps the thing Fernanda traded away. The finale isn't a chase. It's an information war between a network of fear and a network of warmth, and Europe decides which one to believe. **It believes the woman who fed it.**

NEW IDENTITY	-\$9,000
REMAINING	€740

Carried forward: a name, a notebook, and everyone she fed along the way.



las redes

THE DEEP STRUCTURE

There are two networks in this show.

THE COLD ONE

It runs on debt. It moves the cartel's word through fences, brokers, cab ranks, and kitchens — the same rooms she has to enter to find her money. Its currency is fear, and fear travels fast.

The season is the war between them.

The finale is which one Europe decides to believe.

THE WARM ONE

She builds it herself. One meal. One mended seam. One audited ledger. One act of stubborn decency at a time. Its currency is gratitude, and gratitude travels slow.

But it holds.

EVERY CITY IS A MIRROR

Naples shows her devotion unashamed.

Paris shows her independence and what it costs.

Frankfurt shows her money and who it leaves out.

Rotterdam shows her a language close enough to ache.

Lisbon shows her nothing. By then, she has learned to look without a mirror at all.

"Who am I when no one is watching?" The places we're told we can't go — on someone else's map, and in ourselves.

THE LOOK

Never pull back.

The camera lives where she lives: too close, too dense, no establishing comfort. The audience is inside the disorientation with her. Five exceptions, one per stage, each one earned.



SURVEILLANCE ASYMMETRY

Esmeralda is photographed warm and close: handheld, breathing, skin and fabric. Fernanda is photographed cold and far: locked-off, through glass, across rooms. When the two grammars finally share a frame, the season is ending.



THE LANGUAGE LAYER

Foreign text saturates every frame, and Spanish cuts through it like a blade whenever she speaks. Subtitling is selective. Sometimes the audience is as lost as she is. That's the point.



THE INFORMAL DOCUMENT

Receipts, handwritten sums, market chits, a ledger's ruled columns. The season's running arithmetic lives on paper you could hold.



THE UNFINISHED TEXT

The cut-off message is the show's formal signature. Sentences, scenes, and songs that stop mid-thought and resolve only in the finale, when she supplies the ending herself.

DRAFT — NOT SENT

Esme. Te amo. Perdóname por todo. Por favor|

She writes the ending herself.

The last word of the series is the one he couldn't finish.

We'll tell you what it is in the room.